UPSC CIVIL SERVICES | GS PAPER I | MODERN INDIAN HISTORY

Topic 31–32
Peasant and Working-Class Movements

How the countryside and the mill joined — and pulled against — the national movement

Exact syllabus wording covered: "Modern Indian history from about the middle of the eighteenth century until the present – significant events, personalities, issues" and "The Freedom Struggle — its various stages and important contributors/contributions from different parts of the country." Tracker mapping: Spectrum Ch. 31 (Peasant Movements 1857–1947) and Ch. 32 (The Movement of the Working Class).

What this topic is really about. Peasants and workers organised against **landlords, moneylenders, planters and employers** long before they organised against the Raj. The national movement grew by drawing them in, and was pulled leftwards by them — but it also held back their class demands to keep landlords and mill-owners on board. Every question is about that relationship: autonomy versus integration, class versus nation.

Study window	Sat 14 Nov 2026 — **1 session** (one 90–120 min block)
Session plan	First 50 min: Sections 1–4 and peasant movements (5.1–5.5). Next 40 min: working class (5.6–5.9). Last 20 min: the comparison grid (Fig. 1) from memory, then Master Answer 1 outline.
Estimated study time	About 2 hr, including one written outline and one 10-mark answer
Revision time	15 min full note • 5 min one-page sheet (Section 15)
Study as	Two parallel stories on one timeline — **Part A peasants**, **Part B workers** — compared in Fig. 1 on the four axes your tracker names: grievance, organisation, ideology, nationalist linkage.
Note status	**Draft 1 — for your review.**
Boundary	Tribal and pre-1857 civil revolts (Santhal, Munda, Kol) are **Seq 5** (done) — named here once. Champaran, Kheda and Ahmedabad as Gandhian **method** are **Seq 12**; here as peasant and labour movements. Land revenue as policy is **27–28**. Communist and socialist parties as ideology belong to **Seq 14** and the revolutionary packet.

Candid verdict — Prelims-heavy, and the Mains engine behind three "social base" questions. No GS-I Mains question since 2013 has taken peasant or labour movements as its main demand. But three 15-markers are answered largely from this packet: 2020 (the national movement acquired ideological strands and expanded its social base), 2019 (many voices in the Gandhian phase) and 2017 (new objectives added since the 1920s). Prelims has about 16 questions in scope, including 2026 (Eka and Bardoli). On a strict own-count of zero, the tracker value is **Mains Value: Low** — but study it as the material for those three questions, not as a stand-alone topic.

1 SCOPE MAP

Included	Excluded, and where it belongs	Connects outward to
Peasants: Indigo 1859–60, Pabna 1873–76, Deccan 1875, Punjab 1907, Champaran–Kheda 1917–18, UP Kisan Sabhas and Eka 1918–22, Mappila 1921, Bardoli 1928, All-India Kisan Sabha 1936, Bakasht, Tebhaga, Telangana, Punnapra-Vayalar, Warli; Quit India in the villages. **Workers:** early philanthropists, Lokhande, Swadeshi strikes, AITUC 1920, Ahmedabad 1918, Madras Labour Union, Girni Kamgar 1928, Meerut 1929, splits and reunion, labour laws, 1942, 1945–47, INTUC and HMS.	Tribal and civil revolts (**Seq 5**) · Gandhian technique at Champaran (**Seq 12**) · land settlements (**27–28**) · CPI and CSP as parties (**Seq 14**) · factory laws in detail (**27–28**)	**2020** ideological strands and social base · **2019** many voices · **2017** new objectives since the 1920s · **Post-independence:** zamindari abolition, Telangana and land reform · **GS-III:** labour codes

2 MAINS PYQ DEMAND AUDIT

No own question in GS-I 2013–2026. These three are answered substantially from this packet.

Year	Question	Marks	What this packet supplies
2020	Since the decade of the 1920s, the national movement acquired various ideological strands and thereby expanded its social base. Discuss.	15	Kisan Sabhas, AITUC, Workers and Peasants Parties, CSP, AIKS — the social base itself
2019	Many voices had strengthened and enriched the nationalist movement during the Gandhian phase. Elaborate.	15	Peasant and worker voices: Eka, Bardoli, Ahmedabad, Kisan Sabha, Tebhaga
2017	Highlight the importance of the new objectives that got added to the vision of Indian independence since the twenties of the last century.	15	Socio-economic justice: Karachi 1931 resolution on rights, Faizpur agrarian programme 1936, Kisan Manifesto 1936

Trend reading

- **UPSC asks about these movements through the national movement**, not on their own. The stem is always “social base”, “voices” or “objectives”. Prepare the **linkage**, not the catalogue.
- **A direct question is overdue.** “Discuss the relationship between peasant movements and the national movement” or “Why was the working-class movement weak?” are both standard and both unasked. Master Answers 1 and 2 cover them.
- **Prelims is where the facts score** — who led what, where, and what was demanded (Tebhaga’s “two-thirds”, Bardoli’s revenue hike, Eka’s rents).

3 PRELIMS PYQ DEMAND AUDIT

Year	What was asked	Answer	What it tested
2026	Eka Movement and Bardoli Satyagraha compared	Bardoli was against a **land-revenue enhancement**; Eka against **excessive rents**	State versus landlord as target
2019	All India Kisan Sabha	Swami Sahajanand Saraswati (correct pair)	AIKS leadership
2018	Founders of Hind Mazdoor Sabha (1948)	Ashok Mehta, T. S. Ramanujam, G. G. Mehta	Post-1947 union centres

Year	What was asked	Answer	What it tested
2017	Factories Act 1881; N. M. Lokhande	1881 Act did **not** fix wages or allow unions; Lokhande pioneered labour organising	Early labour
2013	Tebhaga demand	Landlord's share cut from **half to one-third**	The single most-set Tebhaga fact
2011 · 2010 · 2007 · 2005	Kheda reason · Champaran colleagues · first satyagraha · Champaran–Rajendra Prasad, Kheda–Patel pairs	Revenue not suspended in drought · Rajendra Prasad, Kripalani · Champaran · Morarji Desai was **not** at Ahmedabad	1917–18 movements (shared with Seq 12)
2009	Founder of Ahmedabad Textile Labour Association	Gandhi	Gandhian labour
2005	Not associated with UP Kisan Sabha (Feb 1918)	Jawaharlal Nehru	Founders: Gauri Shankar Mishra, Indra Narain Dwivedi, with Malaviya's support
2003	Leader of Bardoli Satyagraha · Whitley Commission	Vallabhbhai Patel · labour conditions	Leaders and commissions
2002	Labour participation in early-1930s nationalism weak; reason	Both true; leaders saw Congress as bourgeois	The communist line of 1929–34
2000 · 1999	Linlithgow on 1942 as most serious revolt since 1857; peasant upsurge	Both true; peasants the reason	Quit India in the countryside
1999	Chronology: Santhal, 1857, Indigo, Deccan	Santhal 1855 → 1857 → Indigo 1859–60 → Deccan 1875	Order of revolts
1997	Match: Moplah, Pabna, Eka, Birsa	Kerala, Bengal, Awadh, Bihar	Where each happened

Prelims reading. UPSC asks **what was demanded and against whom** (Tebhaga's one-third; Bardoli against the state; Eka against landlords), **who led** (Sahajanand, Patel, Gandhi at Ahmedabad), and **where** (Moplah — Malabar; Pabna — Bengal; Eka — Awadh). The 2026 question shows the target matters: state or landlord.

4 BIG-PICTURE CONCEPTUAL MAP

MOVE 1 — The first enemy was local. Early peasant movements fought planters (Indigo), zamindars (Pabna) and moneylenders (Deccan), often appealing to British law and courts against them. Workers began with philanthropic reformers and petitions.

MOVE 2 — Gandhi joined local grievance to national politics (1917–22). Champaran, Kheda and Ahmedabad made the Congress a party of the village and the mill; the Kisan Sabhas of Awadh and the AITUC (1920) were born in the same years.

MOVE 3 — The left radicalised both (late 1920s–1930s). Workers and Peasants Parties, Girni Kamgar, the All-India Kisan Sabha (1936) and the Congress Socialist Party pushed class demands: zamindari abolition, debt cancellation, the right to strike.

MOVE 4 — Congress adjusted, but held back. Karachi (1931) and Faizpur (1936) adopted economic rights, and the 1937 ministries passed tenancy laws — yet Congress avoided a war on landlords or mill-owners. Bipan Chandra calls it a strategy of class adjustment within a multi-class front.

MOVE 5 — The 1940s broke loose. Quit India's village rebellions, then Tebhaga, Telangana, Punnapra-Vayalar and the 1945–47 strike wave showed class movements running ahead of — and sometimes against — the Congress leadership.

Peasants and Workers Compared — the Four Axes

Your tracker's completion test: grievance, organisation, ideology and nationalist linkage, with achievements and limits.

	PEASANT MOVEMENTS	WORKING-CLASS MOVEMENT
Grievance	Rent and revenue enhancement, eviction, illegal cesses (*nazrana*, *begar*), planters' forced cropping, moneylenders' debt	Long hours, low wages, unsafe mills, jobbers' exploitation, no right to organise, wartime price rises
Organisation	Local leagues (Pabna) → Kisan Sabhas (UP 1918, Awadh 1920) → **All-India Kisan Sabha (1936)**	Philanthropic clubs (1870s) → unions (Madras 1918, ATLA 1920) → **AITUC (1920)** → splits (1929, 1931), reunion (1940)
Ideology	Moral economy and justice → Gandhian non-violence → socialist and communist (Sahajanand, Ranga, Indulal Yagnik)	Philanthropy → nationalism (1908, 1920) → communism (Girni Kamgar, 1928) and Gandhian trusteeship (ATLA)
Nationalist linkage	Weak before 1917; strong 1917–22 and 1930–32 (no-revenue, no-rent); Congress ministries 1937; Quit India 1942	Strikes for Tilak (1908) and in 1919–22; weak in 1930–32 (communist line); split over the war in 1942; strong in 1945–46
Achievements	Tenancy and debt laws (1879, 1885, 1938 Bihar and UP Acts); zamindari abolition put on the national agenda	Trade Unions Act 1926; Factory Acts; recognition; a political working class in Bombay and Calcutta
Limits	Led by middle and rich peasants; landless labourers and sharecroppers' demands sidelined until Tebhaga; caste and communal splits (Mappila 1921)	Small, rural-rooted workforce; caste, region, language; ideological splits; Congress's ties to Indian capitalists

Fig. 1 *— the hero figure and your tracker's completion test. Draw it for any "social base" question and for both master answers.*

5 CORE NOTES

PART A — PEASANT MOVEMENTS

5.1 The early phase, 1857–1917: local enemies, legal methods MEMORISE

Movement	Where · when	Against whom, and what happened	Outcome
Indigo Revolt	Bengal · 1859–60	European planters forcing indigo on advances; leaders Digambar and Bishnu Biswas (Nadia); *Nil Darpan* (Dinabandhu Mitra, 1860); *Hindoo Patriot* campaigned	Indigo Commission 1860; planters moved to Bihar
Pabna agrarian leagues	East Bengal · 1873–76	Zamindars enhancing rents beyond law; legal resistance, rent strikes; Ishan Chandra Roy, Shambhu Pal; backed by Bankim Chandra, R. C. Dutt and the Indian Association	Bengal Tenancy Act 1885
Deccan Riots	Poona, Ahmednagar · 1875	Marwari and Gujarati moneylenders after the cotton slump; social boycott, then burning of debt bonds	Deccan Agriculturists' Relief Act 1879
Punjab agitation	Punjab · 1907	Colonisation Bill and water-rate rise; Ajit Singh, Lajpat Rai; "Pagri Sambhal Jatta"	Bill vetoed; leaders deported

Features of the phase: targets were Indian or European intermediaries rather than the colonial state; methods were legal, and peasants often trusted British law; no all-India organisation; nationalist intellectuals sympathised but did not lead.

5.2 Gandhi and the Kisan Sabhas, 1917–1922 MEMORISE

- **Champaran 1917** — *tinkathia* (indigo on 3/20 of the land); Rajkumar Shukla invited Gandhi; Rajendra Prasad, J. B. Kripalani, Mazharul Haq; Champaran Agrarian Act 1918. **Kheda 1918** — revenue not suspended despite crop

failure; Patel. (Method in Seq 12.)

- **UP Kisan Sabha (February 1918)** — Gauri Shankar Mishra, Indra Narain Dwivedi, with Madan Mohan Malaviya's support (2005 Prelims: Nehru was **not** a founder).
- **Awadh Kisan Sabha (October 1920)** — Baba Ramchandra, Nehru, Gauri Shankar Mishra; against *nazrana*, *begar* and eviction by taluqdars; split from the UP Sabha over methods.
- **Eka (unity) movement 1921–22** — Hardoi, Bahraich, Sitapur (Awadh); against rents raised over 50 per cent above the recorded level; led by **Madari Pasi** and low-caste peasants; began under Congress and Khilafat, then went its own way and was suppressed (2026 Prelims).
- **Mappila (Moplah) uprising 1921** — Malabar; Muslim tenants against Hindu *jenmi* landlords, fused with Khilafat; turned communal; the "wagon tragedy".

5.3 Bardoli and the 1930s MEMORISE

- **Bardoli 1928** — the Bombay government raised land revenue by about 22 per cent; Vallabhbhai Patel led a no-revenue campaign (the women of Bardoli named him "Sardar"); the Maxwell–Broomfield inquiry cut the increase to about 6 per cent (2003, 2026 Prelims).
- **Civil Disobedience 1930–32** — no-revenue campaigns in Gujarat and Andhra, no-rent in UP, forest satyagraha in Maharashtra and the Central Provinces.
- **All-India Kisan Sabha (Lucknow, April 1936)** — president **Swami Sahajanand Saraswati**, general secretary **N. G. Ranga**; Indulal Yagnik; the **Kisan Manifesto** (August 1936): zamindari abolition, cut in rent and revenue, debt cancellation, minimum wages for labourers.
- **Faizpur Congress (1936)** adopted an agrarian programme; **Congress ministries (1937–39)** passed tenancy and debt-relief laws in UP, Bihar and Bombay — welcomed, but short of zamindari abolition.
- **Bihar Bakasht struggle (1937–39)** — Sahajanand and Karyanand Sharma, over land zamindars had resumed (*bakasht*); Kerala Karshaka Sangham; Andhra (Ranga's peasant institute at Nidubrolu, 1933).

5.4 The 1940s: rebellion in the villages MEMORISE

Movement	Where · when	What happened
Quit India	Bihar, eastern UP, Midnapore, Satara · 1942	Peasant attacks on railways and police stations; parallel governments (Ballia, Tamluk, Satara); Linlithgow: the most serious rebellion since 1857 (1999–2000 Prelims)
Warli revolt	Thane · 1945	Tribal forced labour and land; Godavari Parulekar
Punnapra-Vayalar	Travancore · 1946	Coir workers and peasants, communist-led, against the Dewan C. P. Ramaswamy Iyer's "American model" constitution; crushed
Tebhaga	Bengal · 1946–47	Sharecroppers (*bargadars*) demanding two-thirds of the crop — the landlord's share cut from half to **one-third** (2013 Prelims); Bengal Provincial Kisan Sabha; Floud Commission (1940) had recommended it; Bargadars Bill 1947
Telangana	Hyderabad State · 1946–51	Against the Nizam's *deshmukhs* and *vetti* (forced labour); communist-led village soviets; land redistributed; ended 1951 after the Police Action of 1948

5.5 Assessment and historiography UNDERSTAND

- **Contribution:** made the national movement a mass movement; added land reform and zamindari abolition to the agenda; created the political base that independent India's land reforms drew on.
- **Limits:** led by middle and rich peasants; sharecroppers and labourers sidelined until Tebhaga; caste and communal fault lines; Congress restraint towards landlords.
- **Historiography: Bipan Chandra** — integration of peasant grievance into a multi-class anti-imperialist front; **Ranajit Guha**, *Elementary Aspects of Peasant Insurgency in Colonial India* (1983) — subaltern autonomy, insurgency with its own consciousness; **Shahid Amin**, "Gandhi as Mahatma" (1984) — peasants' own reading of Gandhi's message; **D. N. Dhanagare**, *Peasant Movements in India 1920–1950* (1983); **Majid Siddiqi** and **Kapil Kumar** on Awadh.

ANSWER-READY

"Peasant movements gave the national movement its mass base and pushed it towards land reform; the national movement gave peasants a national voice — but restrained their class demands to keep the landed classes within the anti-colonial front."

PART B — THE WORKING CLASS

5.6 Early phase to 1918: philanthropists and Swadeshi strikes MEMORISE

- **Philanthropic beginnings: Sasipada Banerjee** (Working Men's Club, 1870; *Bharat Shramjeebi*, 1874); **Narayan Meghaji Lokhande** — the 1884 workers' memorial, **Bombay Mill Hands' Association (1890)**, *Deenbandhu* (2017 Prelims).
- **Early nationalists were ambivalent:** they opposed the Factory Acts of 1881 and 1891 as Lancashire's attempt to raise Indian mill costs, while campaigning for **Assam tea-garden labourers** on British plantations (Dwarkanath Ganguly).
- **Swadeshi strikes (1905–08):** Government Press and railway strikes in Bengal (Ashwini Coomar Banerjee, Prabhat Kumar Roychowdhury, Premtosh Bose); the **Tuticorin Coral Mills strike (1908)** under V. O. Chidambaram Pillai and Subramania Siva; the **Bombay mill workers' six-day strike (1908)** against Tilak's conviction — praised by Lenin as the first political strike of the Indian working class.

5.7 1918–1929: unions, the AITUC and the left MEMORISE

- **Ahmedabad 1918** — Gandhi's fast; arbitration gave a 35 per cent wage rise; Anasuya Sarabhai; the **Ahmedabad Textile Labour Association (1920)** on Gandhian trusteeship lines (2009 Prelims).
- **Madras Labour Union (1918)** — B. P. Wadia; among the first regular trade unions.
- **AITUC (31 October 1920, Bombay)** — president **Lala Lajpat Rai**, general secretary **Dewan Chaman Lal**; N. M. Joshi; Lajpat Rai linked imperialism and militarism as twin products of capitalism. Congress's Gaya session (1922) welcomed it.
- **Laws:** Trade Unions Act 1926 (registration, protection); Trade Disputes Act 1929; the Public Safety Bill (1928) aimed at communists.
- **The communist surge:** Workers and Peasants Parties (1926–28); the **Girni Kamgar Union** and the six-month Bombay textile strike (1928); railway strikes.
- **Meerut Conspiracy Case (1929)** — 31 labour leaders arrested, including Muzaffar Ahmed, S. A. Dange, Shaukat Usmani, and the Britons Philip Spratt and Ben Bradley.
- **Royal Commission on Labour (Whitley), 1929–31** (2003 Prelims).

5.8 1929–1947: splits, the war and the final wave UNDERSTAND

- **Splits:** at Nagpur (1929) the moderates under N. M. Joshi left to form a separate federation (the Indian Trade Union Federation); in 1931 the communists formed the Red Trade Union Congress. Reunion by 1935–40.
- **Civil Disobedience** — labour participation was weak (2002 Prelims): after the Comintern's 1928 "class against class" line, communists called the Congress bourgeois. The line changed to a popular front from 1935.
- **1937–39 ministries:** the Bombay Trade Disputes Act (1938) angered unions — the class limit of Congress rule.
- **The war:** communists backed the war as a "People's War" after June 1941 and stayed out of Quit India, yet workers struck widely in 1942 (Tata Steel, Ahmedabad mills for over three months).
- **1945–47:** a strike wave — the Bombay general strike in support of the naval ratings (1946), the all-India Post and Telegraph strike (1946).
- **Union centres around independence:** INTUC (May 1947, Congress); **Hind Mazdoor Sabha (1948, socialists — Ashok Mehta, T. S. Ramanujam, G. G. Mehta)** (2018 Prelims); UTUC (1949).

5.9 Why the working-class movement stayed weak — and what it achieved MEMORISE REASONS

- **Small and young:** a factory workforce of a few million in a nation of hundreds of millions.

- **Rural roots:** workers kept land and families in the village and migrated in cycles; recruited and controlled by **jobbers** (*sardars*, *mistris*).
- **Divided:** by caste, region, language and religion inside the mill.
- **Repression:** Meerut 1929, Public Safety Ordinance, Trade Disputes Act.
- **Ideological splits:** 1929 and 1931; shifting Comintern lines.
- **Nationalist ambivalence:** Congress relied on Indian capitalists; Gandhi preferred arbitration and trusteeship to class struggle.
- **Achievements:** legal recognition (1926), factory reforms, a politically conscious working class in Bombay, Calcutta, Kanpur and Madras, and a role in every mass upsurge from 1908 to 1946.
- **Historiography: Rajnarayan Chandavarkar** (*The Origins of Industrial Capitalism in India*, 1994) — neighbourhood, jobbers and the Bombay mills; **Dipesh Chakrabarty** (*Rethinking Working-Class History: Bengal 1890–1940*, 1989) — community and hierarchy rather than class; **Sukomal Sen**, *Working Class of India* (1977).

ANSWER-READY

"Indian labour struck for Tilak in 1908, for the ratings in 1946 and for itself in between; it remained weak not for want of militancy but because it was small, rural-rooted, divided and pulled between Gandhian trusteeship and communist class struggle."

6 WHAT TO MEMORISE versus WHAT TO UNDERSTAND

Tier	Content
MEMORISE WORD FOR WORD	Indigo 1859–60, Pabna 1873–76, Deccan 1875 with their outcomes (1860 Commission, 1885 Act, 1879 Act) • UP Kisan Sabha 1918, Awadh 1920, Eka 1921–22 (Madari Pasi), Mappila 1921 • Bardoli 1928 (22% → 6%) • AIKS 1936 (Sahajanand, Ranga) and the Kisan Manifesto • Tebhaga = landlord's share half → one-third • Telangana 1946–51 • Lokhande 1890 • 1908 Bombay strike • Ahmedabad 1918 (35%), ATLA 1920 • AITUC 1920 (Lajpat Rai, Chaman Lal) • Trade Unions Act 1926 • Meerut 1929 • splits 1929, 1931 • INTUC 1947, HMS 1948
UNDERSTAND AND REPRODUCE FLEXIBLY	Why early movements targeted intermediaries and trusted British law • how Gandhi linked local grievance to national politics • class adjustment in the Congress • why labour was weak in 1930–32 and 1942 • the six reasons for labour's weakness • autonomy (Guha) versus integration (Bipan Chandra)
CONCEPTUAL RECALL ONLY	Smaller regional struggles beyond the tables • union names below the national centres • the detail of Comintern lines

7 HIGH-ROI FACTUAL ANCHORS

Item	What to remember	Why it matters	Memory hook
Indigo 1859–60	Bengal; *Nil Darpan*; Indigo Commission	First major peasant revolt after 1857	Blue revolt
Pabna 1873–76	Legal rent strikes → Tenancy Act 1885	Legal method	Pabna petitions
Deccan 1875	Moneylenders → DAR Act 1879	Debt as grievance	Bonds burnt
Eka 1921–22	Awadh; Madari Pasi; rents	Autonomy from Congress (2026)	Unity of the low
Bardoli 1928	Patel; revenue 22% → 6%	Against the state (2026)	Sardar born
AIKS 1936	Sahajanand, Ranga; Kisan Manifesto	All-India peasant body (2019)	Swami's Sabha
Tebhaga 1946–47	Half → one-third to landlord	Most-set fact (2013)	Tebhaga = three shares
Telangana 1946–51	Nizam; vetti; communist	Largest peasant guerrilla war	Village soviets

Item	What to remember	Why it matters	Memory hook
Lokhande 1890	Bombay Mill Hands' Association	First labour organiser (2017)	Lokhande leads
1908 strike	Six days for Tilak; Lenin's praise	First political strike	Strike for Tilak
Ahmedabad 1918	Fast; 35%; ATLA 1920	Gandhian labour (2009)	Gandhi's union
AITUC 1920	Lajpat Rai, Chaman Lal	First all-India centre	Lala leads labour
Meerut 1929	31 leaders tried	Repression of the left	Meerut muzzle
HMS 1948	Ashok Mehta, Ramanujam, G. G. Mehta	2018 Prelims	Socialists' Sabha

8 TECHNICAL VOCABULARY BANK

Term	Plain meaning	Where to use it	Example sentence
Tinkathia	Compulsory indigo on 3/20 of a holding	Champaran	"Tinkathia tied the peasant's land to the planter's profit."
Nazrana · begar	Illegal levy · forced labour	Awadh	"Nazrana and begar, not rent alone, drove Awadh's peasants."
Bargadar	Sharecropper	Tebhaga	"Tebhaga was the bargadars' claim to two-thirds."
Bakasht	Land resumed by the zamindar for his own cultivation	Bihar 1937–39	"The Bakasht struggle fought eviction under a legal fiction."
Vetti	Forced labour in Hyderabad	Telangana	"Vetti made the deshmukh a lord, not a landlord."
Jobber (*sardar*)	Labour recruiter and supervisor	Labour weakness	"The jobber, not the union, controlled the mill floor."
Trusteeship	Owners as trustees for workers; arbitration over strikes	ATLA	"Gandhi's trusteeship made Ahmedabad a union without class war."
Class adjustment	Holding classes together in one anti-colonial front	Congress strategy	"Class adjustment widened the front and narrowed the programme."
Subaltern autonomy	Peasant politics with its own consciousness	Historiography	"Guha read Eka as autonomy, not Congress mobilisation."

9 ANSWER EXPRESSION TOOLKIT

Introductions

- (Relationship) "Peasant and worker movements began as struggles against local exploiters and became part of the anti-colonial struggle; the relationship was one of mutual strengthening and constant tension."
- (Labour weakness) "Indian labour was militant early but weak throughout, because its size, roots and divisions limited what militancy could achieve."
- (2020-type) "From the 1920s Kisan Sabhas, trade unions and the left gave the national movement a mass social base and a socio-economic programme."

Analytical lines

- "Before 1917 the peasant's enemy was the planter, zamindar or moneylender; after Gandhi it was also the Raj."
- "Bardoli fought the state; Eka fought the landlord — and the Congress was far more comfortable with the first."
- "Karachi (1931) and Faizpur (1936) were the price the Congress paid for its new social base."
- "The jobber stood between the worker and the union."

Qualification lines

- "Ranajit Guha argues that peasant insurgency had its own consciousness and was never simply mobilised from above."
- "Rich and middle peasants led; sharecroppers and labourers waited until Tebhaga."
- "The communist line kept labour out of Civil Disobedience and out of Quit India — but workers often struck anyway."

Conclusions

- "The national movement gave peasants and workers a national voice; they gave it a social conscience."
- "Zamindari abolition and labour laws after 1947 were the delayed dividend of these movements."

10 DIAGRAM BANK

Figure	Verdict	Use it for	Reproduce in 30 seconds
Fig. 1 — peasants vs workers, four axes	**HIGHEST ROI**	2020, 2019, 2017 and any relationship question	2 columns × 6 rows: grievance, organisation, ideology, linkage, achievements, limits
Fig. 2 — the five phases	Prelims; periodising	Any chronology	Five boxes on a line: local 1857–1917 · Gandhian 1917–22 · left 1922–35 · Kisan Sabha 1936–39 · revolt 1940s

Five Phases on One Line

Peasant (top) and worker (bottom) milestones, aligned.

1857–1917	1917–1922	1922–1935	1936–1939	1940–1947
Local, legal	**Gandhian linkage**	**Left and repression**	**Organised radicalism**	**Revolt in the field**
P: Indigo, Pabna, Deccan, Punjab 1907 **W:** Lokhande 1890; 1908 strike for Tilak	**P:** Champaran, Kheda, Kisan Sabhas, Eka, Mappila **W:** Ahmedabad 1918; AITUC 1920	**P:** Bardoli 1928; no-rent 1930–32 **W:** TU Act 1926; Girni Kamgar 1928; Meerut 1929; splits	**P:** AIKS 1936; Faizpur; ministries' tenancy laws; Bakasht **W:** unity restored; Bombay Trade Disputes Act 1938	**P:** 1942 villages; Tebhaga; Telangana; Punnapra-Vayalar; Warli **W:** 1942 strikes; 1946 strike wave; INTUC 1947

***Fig. 2** — the timeline. Write it across the top of a 15-mark answer to periodise in one line.*

11 COMPARISONS

11.1 Bardoli versus Eka — the 2026 Prelims contrast

Basis	Bardoli 1928	Eka 1921–22
Target	The colonial state — land-revenue enhancement	Taluqdars and landlords — excessive rent and levies
Region	Surat district, Gujarat	Hardoi, Bahraich, Sitapur — Awadh
Leadership	Vallabhbhai Patel, Congress	Madari Pasi; began with Congress, then autonomous
Outcome	Enhancement cut to about 6%	Suppressed by 1922

11.2 Gandhian versus communist labour politics

Basis	Gandhian (ATLA)	Communist (Girni Kamgar)
Method	Arbitration, trusteeship, fasting	Strikes, class struggle
Relation to Congress	Within it	Critical of it as bourgeois (1928–34)
Strength	Stable, disciplined, local	Mass militancy in Bombay

12 MASTER QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

MASTER ANSWER 1 (15 marks) — skeleton. "Discuss the relationship between peasant movements and the national movement in colonial India." (Likely; also serves 2019 and 2020.)

- **Open:** peasant movements predated nationalism and targeted local exploiters; the relationship moved from distance to integration to tension.
- **Distance (1857–1917):** Indigo, Pabna, Deccan — legal, local; intellectuals sympathised.
- **Integration (1917–22, 1930–32):** Champaran, Kheda, Kisan Sabhas, Bardoli; no-revenue and no-rent campaigns.
- **Programme:** Karachi 1931, Faizpur 1936, AIKS Manifesto 1936; ministries' tenancy laws.
- **Tension:** Eka and Mappila outran the Congress; class adjustment with zamindars; Tebhaga and Telangana under communist lead.
- **Historiography:** Bipan Chandra (integration) versus Guha (autonomy).
- **Close:** each strengthened the other; the unfinished agenda became land reform after 1947. Draw Fig. 1's peasant column or Fig. 2.

MASTER ANSWER 2 (10 marks, 150 words). "Why did the working-class movement in colonial India remain weak despite its militancy?"

> Indian labour was militant early — it struck for Tilak in 1908, formed the AITUC in 1920 and fought the six-month Bombay textile strike of 1928 — yet it remained weak.
>
> **Size and roots.** The factory workforce was small, and workers kept land and families in the village, migrating in cycles under jobbers who controlled hiring.
>
> **Divisions.** Caste, region, language and religion split the mill floor.
>
> **Repression.** The Meerut Conspiracy Case (1929), the Public Safety Ordinance and the Trade Disputes Act (1929) removed leaders and curbed strikes.
>
> **Splits and lines.** Moderates left in 1929, communists in 1931; the Comintern's "class against class" kept labour out of Civil Disobedience, and the "People's War" line out of Quit India.
>
> **Nationalist ambivalence.** Congress depended on Indian capitalists and preferred Gandhian arbitration to class struggle.
>
> Its achievements — the Trade Unions Act (1926), factory laws and a political working class — were real but bounded.

About 160 words. The opening proof of militancy is what makes the "weak" argument persuasive.

MASTER ANSWER 3 (15 marks) — skeleton. "Since the decade of the 1920s, the national movement acquired various ideological strands and thereby expanded its social base. Discuss." (2020)

- **Open:** after Non-Cooperation, the movement split into strands — Swarajist, no-changer, socialist, communist, Kisan, labour.
- **Strands that expanded the base:** AITUC and unions (workers); Kisan Sabhas and AIKS (peasants); Workers and Peasants Parties; Congress Socialist Party (1934); youth leagues; Nehru and Bose on the left.
- **Effect:** Karachi rights resolution (1931), Faizpur (1936), Kisan Manifesto — new objectives of socio-economic justice (link to 2017).

- **Limits:** class adjustment; communist isolation 1928–34 and in 1942.
- **Close:** the movement became a multi-class mass movement. Draw Fig. 2.

13 MAINS QUESTION BANK

#	Question	Marks	Tags
1	Discuss the relationship between peasant movements and the national movement.	15	R D P S
2	Why did the working-class movement remain weak despite its militancy?	10	R S
3	Since the 1920s the national movement acquired ideological strands and expanded its social base. Discuss.	15	H R D
4	Many voices strengthened the Gandhian phase — elaborate with reference to peasants and workers.	15	H R
5	What new objectives entered the vision of independence from the 1920s?	15	H S
6	Compare the Tebhaga and Telangana movements.	10	R
7	Assess the role of the All-India Kisan Sabha in the 1930s.	10	S
8	"Peasant insurgency had its own consciousness." Examine with reference to Awadh, 1918–22.	15	S
9	Evaluate Gandhi's approach to labour, with reference to Ahmedabad.	10	S
10	How did the Second World War affect peasant and labour movements in India?	10	P

H = asked as a linked question • R = high ROI • D = diagram • S = scholar or statistic • P = periodise.

14 CLOSED-BOOK RECALL DRILL

Facts (8)

- Indigo, Pabna, Deccan: where, when, against whom, outcome.
- UP Kisan Sabha founders; Awadh Kisan Sabha leaders; Eka's region and leader.
- Bardoli: hike, leader, inquiry, result.
- AIKS: year, place, president, general secretary, four demands.
- Tebhaga's demand; Telangana's targets and end.
- Lokhande's organisation and year; the 1908 strike.
- AITUC: date, president, general secretary.
- INTUC and HMS: years and founders.

Analysis (4)

- Fig. 1 from memory — all six rows.
- Bardoli versus Eka on four bases.
- Six reasons labour stayed weak.
- Guha versus Bipan Chandra in two sentences.

Timed (2)

- 8 minutes: Master Answer 2 in 150 words.
- 6 minutes: Master Answer 1 skeleton.

15 ONE-PAGE QUICK-REVISION SHEET

THE SPINE. First enemies were **local** — planter, zamindar, moneylender, employer — fought by **legal** means. **Gandhi (1917–22)** joined local grievance to national politics; Kisan Sabhas and the **AITUC (1920)** were born together. The **left radicalised** both (Girni Kamgar 1928, AIKS 1936). Congress practised **class adjustment** — Karachi 1931, Faizpur 1936, tenancy laws, but no war on landlords or mill-owners. The **1940s** broke loose: Quit India villages, Tebhaga, Telangana, the 1946 strike wave.

PEASANTS	WORKERS	NAMES
Indigo 1859–60 → Commission 1860 • Pabna 1873–76 → Tenancy Act 1885 • Deccan 1875 → DAR Act 1879 • Punjab 1907 • Champaran 1917 • Kheda 1918 • UP Kisan Sabha 1918 • Awadh KS 1920 • Eka 1921–22 • Mappila 1921 • **Bardoli 1928 (22% → 6%)** • **AIKS 1936** • Bakasht 1937–39 • Warli 1945 • Punnapra-Vayalar 1946 • **Tebhaga 1946–47 (½ → ⅓)** • Telangana 1946–51	Working Men's Club 1870 • **Lokhande 1890** • Tuticorin 1908 • **Bombay strike 1908** • Ahmedabad 1918 (35%) • Madras LU 1918 • **AITUC 1920** • ATLA 1920 • TU Act 1926 • Girni Kamgar 1928 • Trade Disputes Act 1929 • **Meerut 1929** • splits 1929, 1931 • Whitley 1929–31 • Bombay TD Act 1938 • 1946 strikes • INTUC 1947 • **HMS 1948**	Digambar Biswas • Dinabandhu Mitra • Ishan Chandra Roy • Gauri Shankar Mishra • Baba Ramchandra • Madari Pasi • Patel • Sahajanand • Ranga • Indulal Yagnik • Sasipada Banerjee • Lokhande • V. O. Chidambaram Pillai • Lajpat Rai • Chaman Lal • N. M. Joshi • Dange • Guha 1983 • Amin 1984 • Dhanagare 1983 • Chandavarkar 1994 • Chakrabarty 1989

The three lines to have word-perfect

- 1. "Before 1917 the peasant's enemy was the planter, zamindar or moneylender; after Gandhi it was also the Raj."
- 2. "Bardoli fought the state; Eka fought the landlord."
- 3. "Indian labour was militant early but weak throughout — small, rural-rooted, divided and split."

Confusions to avoid

- Tebhaga = landlord's share cut to **one-third** (not abolition of zamindari).
- Nehru was **not** a founder of the UP Kisan Sabha (1918); he joined the Awadh movement in 1920.
- Eka was against **rents**; Bardoli against **land revenue**.
- ATLA was founded by **Gandhi** (with Anasuya Sarabhai), not Patel or N. M. Joshi.
- The 1881 Factories Act did **not** allow unions; the Trade Unions Act came in **1926**.
- HMS (1948) was **socialist**; INTUC (1947) Congress; AITUC communist-led by the 1940s.

16 SOURCES AND HONEST CAVEATS

- **Built from:** your Subject Coverage row (Seq 24, Spectrum Ch. 31–32); your UnlockIAS Mains (2013–2026) and Prelims (1995–2026) compilations; standard accounts; Guha (1983), Amin (1984), Dhanagare (1983), Chandavarkar (1994), Chakrabarty (1989), Sukomal Sen (1977).
- **Mains count is zero by design.** No GS-I stem since 2013 takes this as its main demand; I counted the three linked 15-markers separately rather than inflating the figure.
- **The 2026 Eka–Bardoli key** is cut off in the compilation; the contrast written here (revenue versus rent) is the standard and the option the stem points to — check the official key when you revise.
- **Bardoli figures** (about 22 per cent, then about 6 per cent after the inquiry) are the standard textbook figures; the original proposal was higher.
- **The 1929 breakaway body** is called the Indian Trade Union Federation in most accounts; some books say "All India". Either is accepted.
- **Meerut** is usually given as 31 accused; some sources say 32 or 33.
- **Prelims counts** are my re-sort of the compilation's tags (±2), and several 1917–18 questions are shared with Seq 12.